The NFL's New "Dynamic Kickoff" and Its Impact on the Single Season Passing Record

Jeffrey Hemmelgarn

February 2026

Table of Contents

- Abstract
- Introduction
- Methodology
- Kickoff Rules
- Is There Actually a Difference in Kickoffs?
- How Have Kickoffs Affected Starting Field Position?
- Starting Field Position and Records
    - 2013 Denver Broncos and Peyton Manning
    - 2024 Cincinnati Bengals and Joe Burrow
    - 2025 Los Angeles Rams and Matthew Stafford
    - What This Means for the League Overall
- Other Topics to Consider
- Conclusion
- References

Table of Contents

Abstract

The NFL's new "Dynamic Kickoff" has altered starting field position and potentially the statistical ceilings for quarterbacks. Using drive-level data from the 2000-2025 season via the nflfastR package in R, this study compares the effects on starting field position and passing output. Results have shown that the average starting field position has shifted by 2 yards, while the median starting field position has shifted by 10 yards. This median shift has resulted in an estimated reduction of 700 passing yards per season for top-performing quarterbacks. Case studies of Peyton Manning's record-breaking season in 2013, Joe Burrow's 2024 season, and Matthew Stafford's 2025 season demonstrate how the kickoff rules constrain the ability to break the single-season passing record.

Table of Contents

Introduction

The new kickoff rules in the National Football League (NFL), have generated significant discourse. This discourse mainly revolves around 3 main topics: (1) the new importance of special teams, (2) the strategy of kickoffs, especially at the end of games, and (3) player safety. However, a less discussed implication is the impact it has on player statistics.

This report analyzes the impacts the new "Dynamic Kickoff" has on player stats and season long records that might become unattainable under this new format. This report will specifically look at the single season NFL passing record, currently held by Peyton Manning during the 2013-2014 season as the quarterback for the Denver Broncos in comparison to the single season passing leaders during the last 2 NFL seasons, Joe Burrow in 2024 of the Cincinnati Bengals, and Matthew Stafford in 2025 of the Los Angeles Rams.

Methodology

The data used for this project has been pulled from the "nflfastR" package in R-Studio. The period analyzed spans from the 2000-2001 to the 2025-2026 season. The data only includes regular season data to ensure that only the data that "counts" for the single season record is included. Once filtered, each row of data includes the season, game ID, the offensive team, drive number, the starting field position of each drive, how the offensive team obtained possession, QB ID, and QB name. The original data file includes a plethora of other statistics and variables that are not as relevant to this project. The code utilized will be linked here.

Kickoff Rules

The NFL has now gone two seasons (2024 & 2025) with their new "Dynamic Kickoff" rule, replacing the more traditional format seen at lower levels with a format resembling the Canadian

Football League. This isn't the first time the NFL has made changes to its kickoff procedure, but this specific change is the most noticeable from a viewing perspective, and strategy perspective. A summary of the NFL official kickoff setup rules is:

- The ball is kicked off from the kicking team's 35-yard line.
- The other 10 players for the kicking team are lined up at the receiving team's 40-yard line.
- At least 9 of the returning team players must be lined up between the return team's 30-35-yard line.
- The remaining 1 or 2 return men must be between the 20-yard line and goal line.
- The ball MUST land between the 20-yard line and the back of the endzone for a return to be allowed. This is what is called the "Landing Zone".

The second component to the new rule changes is also where the ball is placed on touchbacks. Under the new rules, if the ball falls in the Landing Zone and the return team allows the ball to roll through the endzone, or they down it in the endzone, the ball is placed at the 20-yard line. If the ball is kicked into the endzone without a return, or out of the back of the endzone, preventing the return team from even having a chance at a return, the ball is automatically placed at the 35-yard line (Austro). These touchback rules are significantly different from previous years where there wasn't a Landing Zone, and the ball was placed at the designated yard line no matter if the ball was returnable or not.

Table 1

Starting Season	Kickoff Type	Kickoff Spot	Touchback Spot	Additional Notes
2000	Standard	30-yard line	20-yard line	
2011	Standard	35-yard line	20-yard line	
2016	Standard	35-yard line	25-yard line	
2024	Dynamic	35-yard line	35 if reaches endzone in air, 20 otherwise	In 2024 the further touchback was the 30-yard line, was moved to the 35-yard line in 2025

Table of Contents

Table 1 above highlights some of the more impactful rule changes the NFL has made regarding the kickoff. For this report each major change will act as the cutoff point for our data. Thus, we will have the following four subcategories: 2000-2010, 2011-2015, 2016-2023, and 2024-Present. A deeper dive into all of the changes made to the NFL kickoff can be found here.

Is There Actually a Difference in Kickoffs?

The next component to analyze was, "Does changing the kickoff actually matter when it comes to starting field position?". Intuitively we would expect the game to be affected by its rules, but that isn't always the case. For the sake of this article, we will be comparing each period listed above to the "Dynamic Kickoff" seasons (2024-2025). To do this, I ran a t-test to compare the averages calculated from nflfastR of each time period. ***Table 2*** summarizes the results.

Table 2

Period	Period Average	Dynamic Kickoff Average	Difference of Mean (old-new)	p-value	Confidence Interval	Result
2000-2010	68.72	69.46	-0.74	<0.001	(-1.05, -0.42)	Averages are different
2011-2015	71.89	69.46	2.43	<0.001	(2.08, 2.78)	Averages are different
2016-2023	71.29	69.46	1.83	<0.001	(1.5, 2.15)	Averages are different

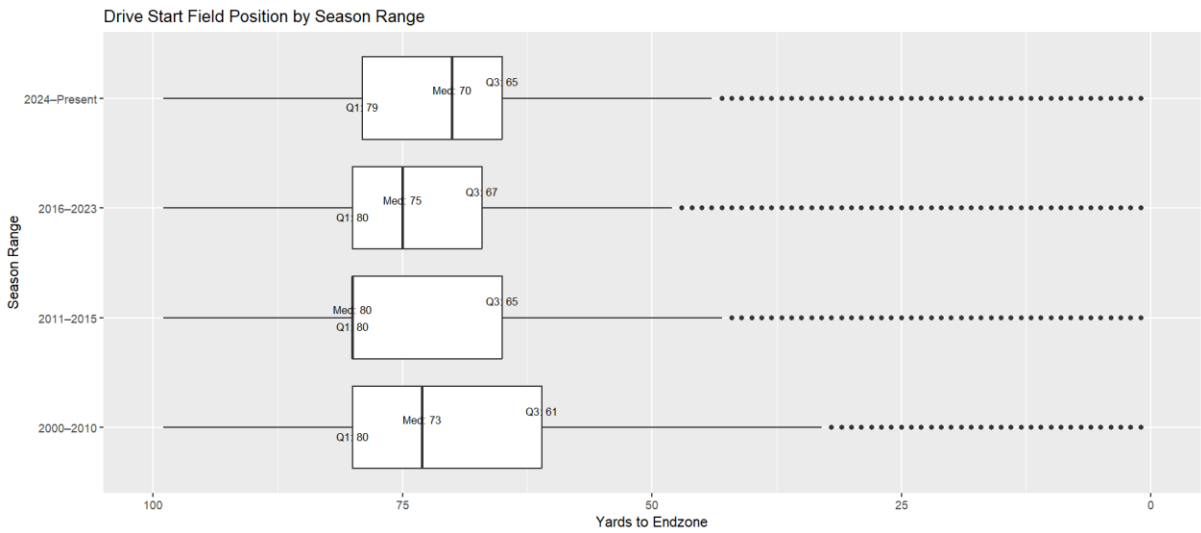
Table 2 shows us that the p-value for each comparison is below our alpha value of 0.01, this provides strong significant evidence to suggest the averages of each period in comparison to the "Dynamic Kickoff" are not equal. A surprising result of this analysis is the starting field position from 2000-2010 was farther away from the endzone than in the recent years. While

statistically significant, the average shift ranges from -0.74 and 2.43 yards, suggesting a modest shift in average starting field position.

How Have Kickoffs Affected Starting Field Position?

Now that we know the different kickoff rules have impacted the game, we must look at "How" the game has been affected. In ***Figure 1***, we see a box plot for each of our designated time periods. Contained within the boxplot are the median (Med), first quartile (Q1), third quartile (Q3), range, and all outliers (·). The values presented are the amount of yardage needed to score a touchdown when a new drive starts. For example, "75" means the team starts on their own 25-yard line and must travel 75 yards to score.

Figure 1

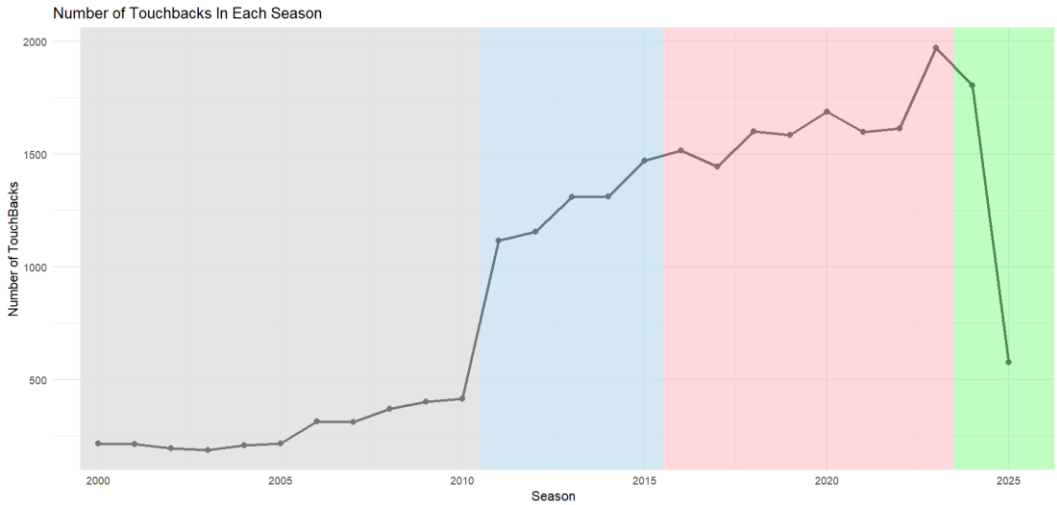


Source: nflfastR

A few notes about the chart above, firstly, the chart above shows the starting field position no matter how the team got the ball. (i.e. kickoff, punt, turnover, etc.) When looking at ***Figure 1,*** the first quartile value for each year except for the most recent period is 80. This is due to the punt touchback spot which is placed at the 20-yard line. However, we can see how the

kickoff rules affected starting field position by analyzing the median value. For the new "Dynamic Kickoff", we see 2 interesting values. First, the median value is what the touchback spot for an "unreturnable" kickoff in 2024. The third quartile (Q3) is the touchback spot for kicking the ball into the endzone during the 2025 season. Teams are still making the kickoff "unreturnable", but at much lower frequency. For each period except for 2000-2010, we see that the median value is the spot of the touchback. This was due to the increased number of returns during that time period. As a result, the inter quartile range (IQR), or the difference between Q3 and Q1 was the largest. We will further analyze the frequencies of touchbacks in ***Figure 2***.

Figure 2



Source: nflfastR

In ***Figure 2*** above, the number of touchbacks has been plotted throughout the years. Each distinct period of kickoff rules has a different background color to quickly notice the effects the rule changes have had. We can quickly see that 2000-2010 had the lowest yearly number of touchbacks. During the 2000s NFL kickoff returns were very common because the kickoff spot was farther away. However, this increase in returns also resulted in an increase in player injury so

the NFL moved the kickoff spot up 5 yards to the 35-yard line. This change greatly impacted the number of touchbacks on kickoffs during the 2010s and up to the “Dynamic Kickoff”.

There are two explanations, one made by each side of the ball, that lead to this trend. First, the kicking team may decide to kick the ball as far as possible through the back of the endzone. This was to eliminate dynamic kickoff returners like Cordarrelle Patterson, Jacoby Jones, and Devin Hester. This allowed the special teams unit to focus on other aspects of the game and nullify the impact of these dangerous returners.

The other decision to be made was by the return team. It was very common for teams to allow the ball to bounce through, or down the ball in the endzone for a touchback. This would have been done if their return team had not had much success over the season. They weren’t willing to take the risk of a poor return and would elect to just take the touchback and the ball at the 25-yard line. Through the 2010s until the new “Dynamic Kickoff”, touchbacks were almost guaranteed.

Lastly, we can see the impact of the new “Dynamic Kickoff”. The first year it was implemented did not result in much of a difference in the number of touchbacks. Kicking teams were still willing to kick the ball in the end zone and have the ball placed at the 30-yard line. However, in 2025 we see a huge impact on the number of touchbacks. Mostly due to the new touchback spot at the 35, but also due to teams having a year to practice and play around with different kicking strategies. This returned the touchback numbers close to the 2000s, but with improved safety numbers because the players are set up differently.

Table of Contents

Starting Field Position and Records

In this section we will dive into the current single season passing yards record, the 2024, and 2025 passing leaders. We will focus on the effects the various kickoff rules have on starting field position and ultimately the ability to break and set the passing record. ***Table 3*** summarizes the opportunity each quarterback had to break the passing record. It includes the number of drives each offense had, the total possible yardage, passing yardage, and the share the quarterback had of each.

Table 3

Quarterback	Drives	Possible Yards	Passing Yards	% Possible	% Actual
P. Manning	202	14369	5477	38.12%	74.85%
J. Burrow	182	12431	4918	39.56%	79.12%
M. Stafford	181	12404	4707	37.95%	70.16%

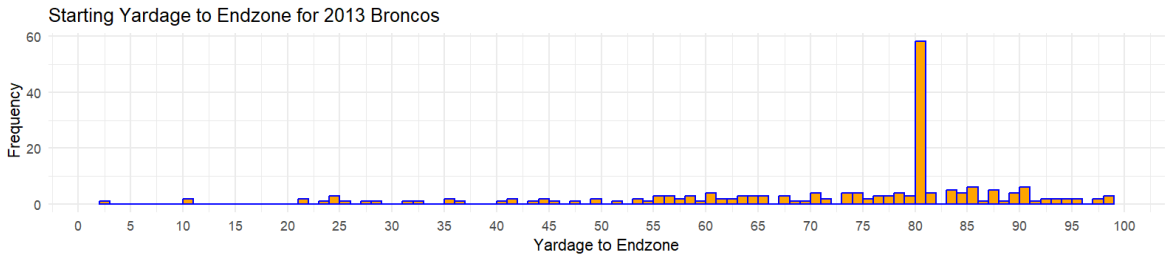
Table 3 highlights the structural constraint in the modern NFL. Both Burrow and Stafford had roughly 2,000 less possible yards than Manning in 2013. Despite this smaller maximum value, Burrow and Stafford had similar efficiency ratings to Manning. However, this increased efficiency was still insufficient to match Manning's record.

2013 Denver Broncos and Peyton Manning

As previously stated, Peyton Manning currently holds the single season passing yards record with 5,477 passing yards. Manning completed this feat during the 2013-2014 season as the starting quarterback for the Denver Broncos. During that season Manning completed 450 passes, averaged 8.3 yards per attempt and averaged 342.3 yards per game across 16 games. Not

to mention he also set a record by throwing 55 touchdowns that year as well (Pro Football Reference). It is the single greatest regular season we have seen from a quarterback. Now, how did Manning manage to accumulate this magnitude of counting stats.

Figure 3



Source: nflfastR

In ***Figure 3*** we see the distribution of starting field position for every regular season drive for the 2013 Broncos. We can easily see the effect of the kickoff rule by the large spike at 80 yards to the endzone. Over half of the Broncos' drives needed 80 yards or more to score a touchdown, with almost 60 drives needing exactly 80 yards. This distribution, in addition to the higher-than-normal number of drives, a perfect storm for Manning to set the single season record was created.

The Broncos that year had 202 offensive drives. In comparison, the team with the most offensive drives in a single season since 2000 was the 2023 Cleveland Browns with 223. These drive counts do include drives that were close to the end of a half that might result in a kneel to end it, but that number is negligible in this context. With those 202 drives, the Broncos and Manning had the possibility to record 14,369 total yards on offense. Of those 14,369 yards, the Broncos recorded 7,317 total yards of offense. Manning through the air accounted for over 38% of all total possible yardage, and almost 75% of actual yardage. Since 2000, that season for the

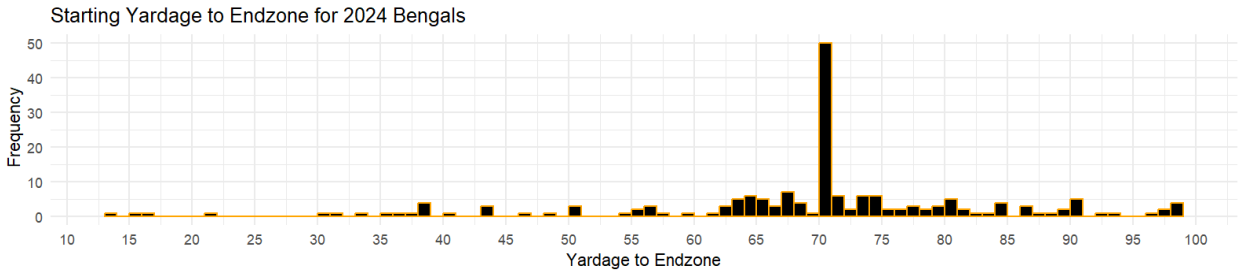
Table of Contents

Broncos resulted in the 2nd most yards covered by an offense, only behind 2011 New Orleans Saints (The same year Drew Brees threw for 5,476 yards). However, the 2013 Broncos were the only team in the top 20 of actual yardage that had over 200 drives (nflfastR). The Broncos' overall offensive efficiency wasn't spectacular, they had more opportunities to possess the ball, typically with more possible yardage which allowed Manning to "air it out" more frequently.

2024 Cincinnati Bengals and Joe Burrow

In the first year of the "Dynamic Kickoff", Joe Burrow threw for 4,918 yards, the 22nd most all-time in a single season. That season Burrow completed 460 passes, averaged 7.5 yards per attempt, and averaged 289.3 yards per game across the 17-game season (Pro Football Reference). With an additional game (a conversation for a different day), Burrow still couldn't eclipse 5,000 passing yards despite completing more passes than Manning.

Figure 4



Source: nflfastR

In ***Figure 4*** we see the distribution of starting field position for the 2024 Bengals. Similarly to the Broncos' distribution, we see a large spike where the touchback spot was. However, this time it is 10 yards closer to the endzone, only requiring 70 yards to reach the endzone. Even with the adjustment to the touchback spot, the kicking team still preferred to have the ball spotted at the 30-yard line.

Table of Contents

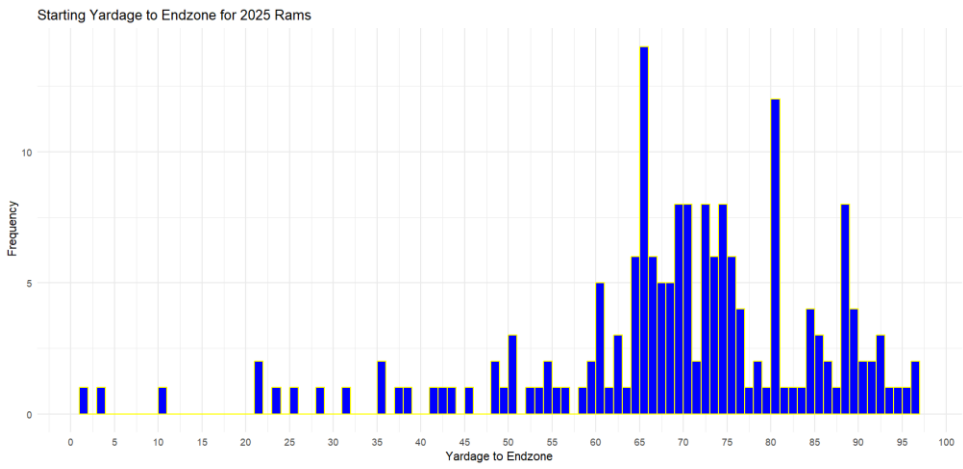
The Bengals in 2024 only had 182 offensive drives, significantly less than the 2013 Broncos, and actually in the lower half of the league in 2024. Those 182 drives resulted in a possible yardage of 12,431. Of those 12,431 possible yards, the Bengals offense recorded 6,216 yards. With Burrow throwing for 4,918 yards, he accumulated almost 40% of all possible yardage, and 79% of all actual yardage (nflfastR). Both percentages are higher than Manning's record-breaking season in 2013. However, the lower number of drives and possible yardage limited Burrows' ability to break the record. If we use the Broncos' possible yardage, and Burrow's contributions, Burrow would've recorded 5,677 passing yards, 200 more than Manning's record. The greatest limitation for Burrow was his starting field position and number of drives. His efficiency and caliber of play were certainly high enough to challenge the record in a different era and framework.

2025 Los Angeles Rams and Matthew Stafford

The last quarterback we will analyze is Matthew Stafford's 2025 season in which he threw 4,707 yards, putting this season as 47th all time. Unlike Manning's and Burrow's seasons, Stafford had less than 400 completions, but averaged 7.9 yards per attempt, and averaged over 276 yards per game (Pro Football Reference). Just like Burrow, with an additional game Stafford couldn't reach the 5,000-yard mark. Nonetheless, this stat line ultimately led Stafford to win his first MVP in his then 17-year career.

Table of Contents

Figure 5



Source: nflfastR

In ***Figure 5*** we can immediately see the impact the "Dynamic Kickoff" had on starting field position. Firstly, the frequency scale is significantly smaller in comparison to the two previous charts. The most occurring field position was at the 35-yard line (65 yards to the endzone), this is still unsurprising due to the touchback spot on kickoffs being set there. We also see a larger spike at the 20-yard line, the touchback spot for punts. However, we see a larger variance in starting field position due to the increase in returns that typically end between the 20 and 35-yard line.

In 2025 the Rams had a total of 181 drives, 1 less than Burrow and the Bengals in 2024. Within those 181 drives, the Rams had 12,404 possible yards to gain. Through their 17-game regular season the Rams accumulated 6,709 total yards. With Stafford recording 4,707 passing yards, he accounted for roughly 38% of all possible yardage, and 70% of all actual yardage (nflfastR). Stafford accounted for roughly the same percentage of possible yardage as Manning

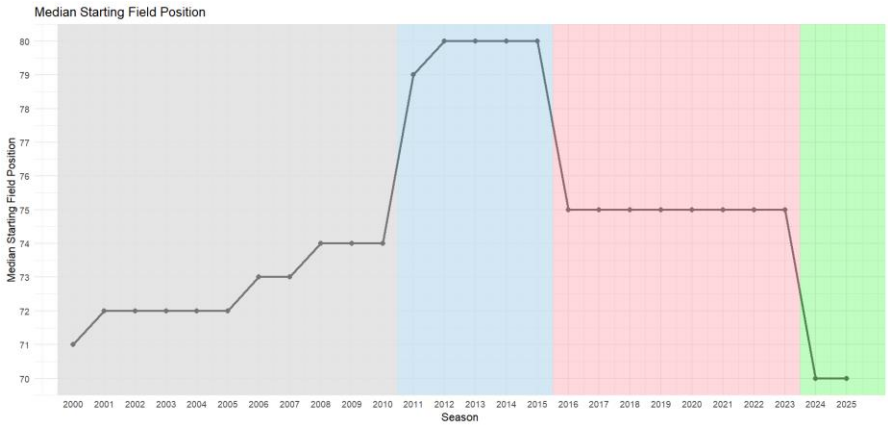
but trailed in share of actual offensive yardage. Both rates for Stafford were lower than Burrow's rates in 2024.

When using Stafford's share of all yardage recorded and the Broncos' actual yardage, Stafford would've reached the 5,000 threshold but would still be roughly 300 yards short of the record. When using the Broncos' possible yardage and Stafford's share, he would've been able to match Manning's record. Again, the greatest limitation for Stafford was the number of drives and possible yardage. Additionally, the Rams' offense gained a larger percentage of rushing yards in comparison to the other two teams. Ultimately it would've taken a heroic effort for Stafford to even sniff the passing record.

What This Means for the League Overall

In Manning's 2013 season, the median starting point of his drives was at the 20-yard line (80 yards to the endzone). For Burrow and Stafford, their median starting point was at the 30-yard line (70 yards to the endzone). This 10-yard difference reduces the total possible yardage per drive. In ***Figure 6***, we see the median shift in starting field position. Again, each kickoff era is highlighted with a different color to emphasize the significance of these rule changes.

Figure 6



Source: nflfastR

Table of Contents

Although there is this 10-yard shift, there are a multitude of factors that are beyond the scope of this analysis. This includes drives starting at in the redzone or near your own endzone, the difference in late-game play calling when the offensive team is winning or losing, how much a 10-yard shift affects end of drive outcome(i.e. having to punt instead of attempting a field goal), and time constrains at the end of the half. For modeling purposes, we assume a uniform 10-yard shift per drive.

When using an average (from 2000-2025) of 185 drives, there are 1,850 fewer possible offensive yards. Using the passing-yard share amongst our 3 quarterbacks (38.67% of possible yardage), approximately 715 fewer passing yards are attributable solely to starting field position. This estimate assumes a linear proportional relationship between possible yardage and passing yardage. This means for each additional yard of median starting position, the QB loses out on 71.5 passing yards per season.

Under this framework, Burrow would surpass Manning's record, while Stafford would've only been 55 yards short.

Other Topics to Consider

While kickoffs are not the only way a team gets the ball to start the drive, isolating kickoffs will allow us to measure the direct impact they have.

In 2013, Manning had 85 drives start after a kickoff, 42 of which resulted in a touchback. Under a 10-yard field-position shift framework, an additional 420 yards are possible across the season. Applying the passing-yard share amongst our 3 quarterbacks (38.67%), this equates to 162 passing yards on the year, solely attributable to touchbacks (nflfastR).

Burrow had similar kickoff frequency in 2024, with 88 kickoff-starting drives and 48 touchbacks. A 10-yard field-position framework results in an additional 480 possible yards, or roughly 186 passing yards.

This narrower estimate suggests that kickoff touchbacks contribute meaningfully to passing-yard ceilings. However, they only account for a fraction of the broader 715-yard structural estimate derived from all-drive median shifts.

Conclusion

The early years of the "Dynamic Kickoff" have already shown how rapidly strategic behavior in the NFL can shift. In 2013, only 12 teams had at least a 50% return rate. In 2024 every team had less than a 50% return rate. This rate flipped on its head in 2025 as every team had a return rate of over 64% (nflfastR). These shifts highlight how rules alter kickoff-return rate, risk tolerance, and ultimately field position.

Though early in the "Dynamic Kickoff" era, the compression of possible yardage is clear. Even marginal improvements in starting field position can translate into hundreds of yards over the course of a season. Under proportional estimates derived in this analysis, a 10-yard shift in median starting position corresponds to approximately 700 passing yards across the 17-game season.

Manning's 2013 record was achieved under conditions that resulted in high drive volume and maximal yardage opportunity. In contrast, recent quarterbacks have operated within a more constrained opportunity framework. For example, Burrow's season in 2024 demonstrates that elite efficiency alone isn't enough when yardage ceilings are reduced.

However, kickoff structure is only one component of the very complex process of analyzing starting field position. Defensive efficiency, turnover rate, and pace of play all interact with starting field position to determine a quarterback's passing output. As more seasons unfold with the "Dynamic Kickoff", additional research analyzing all of these components will provide a better estimate of its long-term statistical impact.

What is already evident is that even a small structural change can have a compounding effect over the course of a season.

Rule changes alter starting field position, which alters total possible yardage, and total possible yardage constrains a quarterback's overall output. Ultimately, these structural changes reshape the statistical ceilings that define NFL history.

Table of Contents

References

Austro, Ben. "Chronology of Kickoff Rules Changes." *Football Zebras*, 17 May 2018, www.footballzebras.com/2018/05/chronology-of-kickoff-rules-changes/.

"Get Started with NflfastR." *Nflfastr.com*, 2017, nflfastr.com/articles/nflfastR.html. Accessed 19 Feb. 2026.

Pro Football Reference. "Pro Football Statistics and History | Pro-Football-Reference.com." *Pro-Football-Reference.com*, 2018, www.pro-football-reference.com/.